

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

Medavakkam » Srinivasa Nagar » Kathipara Junction » Kovilambakkam » Sadasivam Nagar » Potheri » Selaiyur » Sembakkam » St.Thomas Mount » Madipakkam » Urappakkam » Paranur



IT'S A PERFECT 10

This all-women Tamil theatre troupe, a majority of them hailing from Pallikaranai and Velachery, will be staging their next production on August 29 **P2**



'COOKING UP' A CHALLENGE FOR CHEFS

Over 70 participants took part in this competition designed to test their culinary knowledge and kitchen skills **P6**

'Veeraraghavan Eri should have been restored first'

As excess water flows from Veeraraghavan Eri into Thiruneermalai Periya Eri, attention should have been paid to the former's health; at present, it is filled with sewage and overrun with water hyacinth

V. SANTHANAM

The Water Resources Department (WRD) should have first restored Veeraraghavan Eri (which runs through Chromepet and Tambaram Sanatorium) and then followed it up with the restoration of Thiruneermalai Periya Eri.

Excess water from Veeraraghavan Eri flows into Thiruneermalai Periya Eri, the former serving as a supplementary water channel to the latter.

Veeraraghavan Eri is filled with sewage and overrun with water hyacinth. Recently, waste water from Veeraraghavan Eri had drained into Thiruneermalai Periya Eri, washing away the desilted and deepened soil (bunds). Now is the right time for Tambaram City Municipal Corporation, WRD and the State Government to take steps to restore Veeraraghavan Eri; if not, the restoration work at Thiruneermalai Periya Eri will go in vain.

Veeraraghavan Eri (*in picture*) is a source of groundwater for Government Hospital Thoracic Medicine, National Institute of Siddha, Chengalpattu District Government Hospital, and for residents of Durga Nagar, Tambaram Sanatorium and The New Colony, Chromepet.

If Veeraraghavan Eri is not restored, the groundwater will get depleted, forcing residents to fend for water.

The civic body should take action against those discharging sewage into Veeraraghavan Eri in Chromepet. The region has a comprehensive underground drainage network.

V. Santhanam is a resident of The New Colony, Chromepet



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It's a perfect 10

This all-women Tamil theatre troupe, a majority residents of Pallikaranai and Velachery, will be staging their next production on August 29

Sarvam Nataka Priyas, an amateur all-women Tamil theatre troupe, will be presenting its 10th production, *Gajasanakasi*, on August 29 in Pallikaranai. Known for its focus on women-centric stories and engaging performances, the troupe has been steadily building a repertoire that combines humour with observations on everyday life.

Gajasanakasi is a comic play revolving around six women and their take on life. Each character brings a distinct perspective and personality to the story. Their interactions lead to several hilarious situations and provide plenty of scope for humour.

The play promises to be an entertaining, light-hearted production that allows the audience to unwind and enjoy an evening of laughter.

'*Gajasanakasi*' is written by R. Kesavan who is well-known in Tamil theatre circles. The music is scored by popular music composer

Dakshin. The script is infused with unbridled humour, wit and sarcasm while drawing references from the current social and political scenario in the state and the country. These contemporary references make the play relatable to the audience and adds an element of topical humour to the narrative, said a release.

Journey of drama troupe

"I am an avid drama lover and have acted in several plays during my school and college days. Later as a journalist I have watched and reviewed plays staged by amateur and professional players. During the pandemic, when most of us were stuck at homes. I thought drama as a form of art will be a stress-buster not only for the players but also the audience. Since I live in a 203-flat gated community, I shared my thoughts of forming a drama group with my friends. Some of them jumped at the idea and Sarvam Nataka Priyas was born in November 2021," says B. Vijayalakshmi, founder of Sarvam Nataka Priyas and a senior journalist.

Sarvam Nataka Priyas comprises career women, homemakers



From a previous production; and (below) the team rehearse for their upcoming show

and techies who stay in and around Pallikaranai and Velachery. The troupe has staged their plays in Chennai and other cities including at colleges, clubs, gated communities, cultural centres and old age homes. Rehearsing for the play is one big challenge these women face as all of them have different work timings and household chores. Sometimes they rehearse online and meet up after 9 p.m.

Beyond comedy, the drama troupe has experimented with thriller. *Konnathu Neethana?*, their ninth production, written by Kesavan was a thriller. The whodunit

marked a departure from the troupe's earlier productions and gave the performers an opportunity to explore a more intense and suspense-driven narrative, added the release. The play's intriguing storyline, coupled with the performances and suspenseful moments, struck a chord with theatre-goers. From humour and satire to mystery and suspense, the all-women ensemble wants to explore varied themes while keeping its performances engaging and accessible to audiences.

For details, write to sarvamnatakapriyas@gmail.com

Other productions

Their debut short play 'No escape from Corona' was topical and an instant hit with the audience. The play 'Ninaithal Nadathalam' was about the bond women of different age groups share in a ladies hostel. 'Ethu Suthanthiram' staged during Republic Day dealt with challenges faced by parents in choosing a groom or bride for their children during these changing times. 'Natpukkaga Naalu Poi' dealt with friends in an apartment helping each other during emergencies. 'SMS', staged to mark Women's Day, revolved around the predicament of a career woman turned homemaker and her family who realises her value with the help of three goddesses Sakthi, Mahalakshmi and Saraswati in a humorous way. The plot of 'Idharkuthane Aasai Pattai Narada' was woven around Vaikuntam and Bhoologam and was about the nine characters being themselves without any iota of falsehood.

Saplings planted at lake bund



T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

On August 15, more than 500 palm tree saplings were planted on the bund of Thiruneermalai Periya Eri along Thiruneermalai Road. A global IT services firm, along with Naanai—a group of volunteers from the banking and IT sectors—residents

of Thiruneermalai, and volunteers of the Thiruneermalai Periya Eri Padhukappau Kuzhu, organised the plantation drive.

Over 30 volunteers, including local residents, participated in the drive. The saplings were planted in two rows: one row five to six feet above the bund soil, and the other five to six feet from the first row

(above the saplings). Trenches for the saplings were dug to a depth of around 10 to 20 centimeters, B. Saravanan, a core volunteer at Thiruneermalai Periya Eri Padhukappau Kuzhu, said.

This initiative aims to stabilise the soil with deep root systems, preventing erosion and landslides during heavy rain. It also reduces wind and wave action against the embankment and supports local biodiversity. Birds and small animals use the trees for shelter and food.

Prior to the plantation drive, the Kuzhu obtained permission from Pallavaram MLA J. Kamatchi and received approval from the Water Resources Department. After the event, Naanai volunteers engaged with residents, explaining the plantation process and the concept of a saplings bank.

Two-day property expo in September



The Hindu Property Expo - 2026 will be held on September 5 and 6 at Chennai Trade Centre, Nandambakkam.

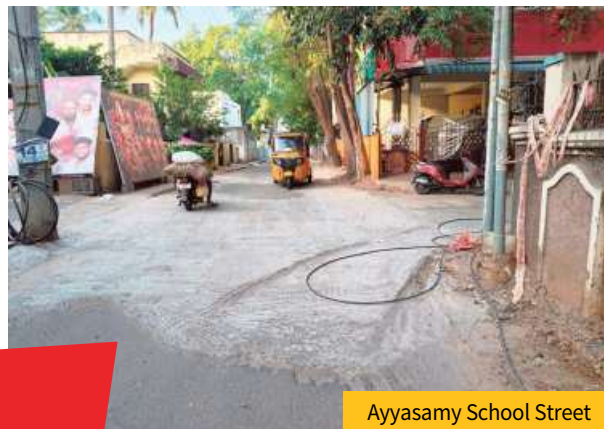
Visitors can explore a wide range of premium residences, plots, farmlands, farmhouses, commercial spaces, and investment opportunities. The expo offers an opportunity to meet developers, compare projects, understand available options, and make informed property

decisions.

Scan the QR code to register or visit: newsth.live/PFC2026PA

For details, call 9841273713 / 9841810070





T. ARVIND

Motorists and school-children in several parts of Tambaram City Corporation are facing a fresh hazard on roads already affected by potholes and damaged surfaces: uneven patches laid after roads are dug up for water supply and underground drainage (UGD) works.

In several locations, the excavated portions have been restored with concrete, but the surface has not been brought back to its original level. Two-wheeler riders and cyclists are forced to suddenly change direction to avoid the rough patches, while motorists have to slow down and manoeuvre around them, affecting the smooth flow of traffic.

A visit to several roads from Pallavaram to Tambaram showed that the problem was particularly acute at a number of locations. Here are six trouble spots:

Driving along Sivasankaran Street near Pallavaram railway station towards the flyover leading to Shandy Road has become difficult. The approach to the flyover has several uneven and damaged portions, forcing motorists to move towards either edge of the carriage-way to avoid the rough surface. Sudden U-turns by autorickshaws and vehicles from the service road add to the risk. There is also a lack of clarity over whether the affected portion comes under Tambaram Corporation or the Cantonment Board. Corporation Commissioner S. Balachandran said he would look into the issue.

Railway Border Road, popularly known as Vaishnava College Border Road, is used by hundreds of motorists to Tirusulam towards the Metro station or seeking to avoid GST Road congestion. A portion of the road, which was laid about six months ago, was dug up last month for pipe-laying work. Though it was subsequently filled and restored with concrete, the patch remains uneven. With the road already narrow, two-wheeler riders tend to avoid the affected portion.

On Chitlapakkam Main Road, a stretch from the R.P. Road junction was recently dug up for laying water pipelines and restored with

Poor restoration of roads dug up for pipeline works forces motorists, cyclists to manoeuvre around rough surfaces

Six trouble spots



concrete. While several patches are manageable, the stretch diagonally opposite Varadaraja Cinemas near

the autorickshaw stand remains particularly uneven. Street vendors said two-wheeler riders, including women, had lost balance while negotiating the patch.

Ayyasamy School Street in Ward 35, Chromepet, located between the MTC depot, a petrol bunk, several schools and the MIT campus, has also been dug up at multiple points for drinking water pipeline work. The uneven surfaces have made cycling difficult for school students. Saranya, a student, said her bicycle had suffered punctures at least twice in the past fortnight while using the road.

The Agaram Main Road near the Camp Road junction in Ward 45, Tambaram, presents a different problem. A portion of the road is covered with sand and mud in connection with the Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board's Nemmeli Seawater Desalination Project. A mound of mud in the middle of the road poses a risk to motorists, particularly school and college students. Councillor 'Kodi' Dhamodharan said concrete patches were being laid on a priority basis and that the road would be re-laid soon.

At the Thiruporur Road-Hasthinapuram bus stand junction, encroachments have already reduced the available road space. A large pothole at the junction makes it difficult for motorists, pedestrians and school and office-goers to negotiate the stretch.

Munusamy, a long-time resi-

Corporation Commissioner's response

Corporation Commissioner S. Balachandran said the cost of road works and shortage of bitumen were among the factors affecting full-scale blacktopping. Concrete patches, he said, were being laid on a priority basis as an immediate solution to ensure the continuous movement of vehicles. "Instead of waiting for blacktopping, concrete mix is done to ensure continuous free flow of vehicle movement, taking into account the traffic mobility of the road," he said. On complaints about uneven surfaces, he said defects would be rectified if brought to the Corporation's notice. He also appealed to the public to wait until the cement had dried fully before using the repaired portions, as movement over the wet surface could leave impressions and result in uneven patches. Meanwhile, cracks have reportedly developed on the MIT flyover roundabout. S.M. Govindarajan, founder-president of the United Federation of Residents' Welfare Associations under Tambaram Corporation, said the Highways Department had filled the cracks with concrete or bitumen instead of relaying the affected portion fully. He also pointed to a large crater-like depression on the downward slope of the Pallavaram-Thoraipakkam flyover on GST Road east, which he said had become accident-prone. "I myself skidded twice on the stretch. When contacted, the Highways Department said a new tender would be called," he said. Residents and activists urged the Corporation and Highways Department to adopt better restoration methods for roads dug up for pipelines and other development works, instead of relying on temporary measures.

dent, said several minor accidents caused by the poor road condition went unreported. "Before any major tragedy occurs, the Corporation should prioritise blacktopping the roads to ensure motorists' safety," he said.



Ticking on behind the barricades

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

Zenith Watch Co at
Kutchery Road in
Mylapore.

Somewhere between the ticking of a century-old pendulum clock and a modern, sleek wrist watch, Zenith Watch Co. on Kutchery Road has ensured two distinct eras of time live side by side. A sweep of the eye taking in the walls of this shop that stares at Metro Rail barricades presents this sumptuous display of the past and the present. The walls are decorated with old, ornate timepieces, repaired and ready for delivery; and these walls also display shelves holding modern wristwatches out of factories and packed ready for sale.

Since 1954, this shop at Kutchery Road, near Luz signal in Mylapore, has been serving customers seeking to preserve timepieces of the past, hallowed by their personal memories, as well as watches and clocks just out of the blocks and dew-fresh in the market.

Founded by Mallick Pasha, the shop has never had a change of address. And even in these difficult times, when Metro Rail work has redrawn pathways, both for pedestrians and motorists, the shop resiliently stays put at this address. Mahaboob Pasha, who runs this family business, points out that even old customers accustomed to walking through the doors of this shop struggle to find their way to those familiar doors, as Metro Rail work has engineered a maze of new pathways through route diversions and blockages. By virtue of the diversity of its services, Zenith depends on revisits by old customers as well as walk-ins by new ones. The “barricades” across Luz Corner, on Kutchery Road and Luz Church Road hinder both processes.



“New customers find it difficult to notice the shop, while the old ones find it difficult to reach the shop,” he says.

But Mahaboob sounds like someone who has taken these challenges in his stride. At 58, this man has spent more than three decades amidst the “chimes of time”, having taken over the reins of the shop when he was in his twenties. Back then for this M.Com graduate, there was no dearth of career options. “This is a family business and I cannot leave it; hence I chose this,” he says. There was a time when he worked alongside the technicians at the shop, as a repairer of timepieces. Today, he sticks to

the management side of the business, leaving the repair of broken and malfunctioning timepieces to the technicians on the rolls. Mahaboob notes spare parts are sourced from Mumbai and Delhi when they are unavailable locally.

On whether a plethora of other devices marking time such as the mobile phone, the laptop and so on have made a dent in the attraction of the wristwatch, his answer is an emphatic ‘no’. Mahaboob observes that it remains firmly where it belongs: on the wrist. Largely for inveterate followers and buyers of new wristwatch models, Zenith stocks up on non-branded wristwatches, largely wallet-friendly.

On retaining his old customer base, Mahaboob notes hospitality on the other side of the counter remains an effective glue keeping that loyalty intact. While valuing face-to-face, in-person interactions, Zenith has ensured the connections are sustained by technology. Its website allows customers to track repairs using their bill numbers; it showcases wristwatches, wall clocks, and other timepieces for sale. So, what is it that sustains Zenith as it is hemmed in by Metro Rail barricades? This probably: keeping stride with technology without losing that personal, human touch.

Celebrating Madras Day (August 22), Resilience Series tracks old markets and enterprises in the city that are under the shadow of a major civic infrastructure work but are soldiering on with inimitable poise.



“New customers find it difficult to notice the shop, while the old ones find it difficult to reach the shop.”

Established in 1954, seller and mender of timepieces Zenith Watch Co at Kutchery Road in Mylapore has never had a change of address. In recent times, it has been facing a massive challenge on account of route diversions and road blockages caused by Metro Rail work. The enterprise however seems to have taken this difficulty in its stride. A little distance away, on the same road is a one-man enterprise Peer & Sons, established in 1963, that repairs watches and clocks; and it displays similar fortitude



Alone with the timepieces

At Peer & Sons on Kutchery Road, a son is keeping his father’s memory alive by enthusiastically practising a skill imparted to him by the senior

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

On that part of Kutchery Road, where the Buckingham Canal flows sluggishly under a bridge, S. Shakil Ahmed operates from a shop smaller than a niche in a dovecote. The shop was once larger, recalls Shakil, but as the owner reclaimed a part of it for another enterprise, it shrunk to its present dimensions. But this small shop still catches the eye for its wall displays: clocks, either *demode* or delectably antique, depending on the eye beholding them. Another eye-catching feature is the enseigne above the entrance that announces the enterprise as Peer & Sons. When quizzed about the name and its homonymic alignment with the iconic P. Orr & Sons on Mount Road, Shakil sounds a tad amused as he offers a reply: obviously, when they see this shop, they know the two are galaxies apart. But when they hear the name ‘Peer & Sons’ over the phone, they would be confused for a split second. And the name was not carefully chosen to evoke that iconic shop, remarks Shakil, just to reflect that it was started by his father S.K. Peer.

S.K. Peer had opened this shop in 1963 and continued in the saddle till his demise in 2008. Shakil relishes reminiscing about the unquestioning obedience with which he followed in his father’s footsteps, not in 2008 but way back in 1991 when the senior was at the height of his prowess as a mender of timepieces and he was just a school student. Shakil joined his father as his understudy in 1991, right after finishing his Class X board exams.

“I did not even wait for my results,” he says with a faint laugh at the memory.

“If my father asked for something, it was always a yes,” states Shakil, his decision driven by a straightforward logic: if his father needed him at the shop, that was reason enough to be there.

He observes that for parents to get a ‘yes’ from their children today, they would have to first answer a gazillion ‘whys’. Shakil, who has three children, two girls and a boy, all of them falling within the Gen Z bracket, is at peace with the current generation’s questioning mindset as they are spoilt for choice in terms of career options, and have information at hand to suss those careers out.

To a question if he ever regrets not having taken a different career path, Shakil’s answer is a ‘no’, but he qualifies it by admitting that on rare occasions,



S. Shakil Ahmed at Peer & Sons on Kutchery Road.

the thought has crossed his mind. That thought most likely occurred during the pandemic and in recent times, on account of Metro Rail work at the Luz Corner (where Kutchery Road meets Luz Church Road meet) restricting access to his shop. That thought gets counterbalanced by his awareness of the benefits of being one’s own boss.

“If there is a function, I can attend it without prior leave complications; if I want to travel, I can take a few days off and do so,” he smiles.

He has commendably built a livelihood just by the practice of the craft of repairing timepieces, has managed to give his children good and meaningful education (the two daughters are in college and the son in school).

After his father’s death in 2008, Shakil has been running the shop in a veritable one-man show spending that vast chunk of his waking hours (that is, from 10.a.m. to 9p.m.), sitting hunched over timepieces, peering at them through a magnifying eyepiece. The punch-in punch-out time is sometimes longer: during the pandemic, he began taking delicate and major repairs home, a habit that has stuck with him ever since. His workbench has witnessed everything from a Seiko to a 1960s Omega; and also those ornate tall, weight-driven pendulum clocks, colloquially called grandfather and grandmother clocks depending on their height and size. His customer base includes collectors of antique clocks. He accepts every timepiece that comes his way, from the grand to the commonplace. Repairs of antique clocks can soak up considerable time.

Availability of spare parts can sometimes pose a challenge. When unable to find spare parts, he has fashioned them himself, says Shakil. But obviously, there is a limit to what you can fashion yourself; the sustainable option is to have dealers who can hand them over to you. On a normal day though, he sources spares from dealers. He also buys old clocks to salvage those parts that are in working order.

Now, the question that stares at any enterprise sustained by successive generations. Would the next generation take the baton from Shakil and continue the legacy started by his father S.K. Peer? His children might likely choose different fields, and Shakil admits the possibility of the business continuing through them being thin. For now, Shakil remains at his bench, turning back time by getting old timepieces ticking again. And he luxuriates in the sweet sound of a timepiece ticking and sounding back to life.

Free and subsidised dialysis service providers in Chennai



LIFFY THOMAS

16 and counting

It was after a stint in Canada that nephrologist Georgi Abraham decided to start a dialysis centre at Chennai in the mid-2000s.

The Tanker Foundation Dialysis Centre started in a humble way at Georgi Abraham’s father-in-law’s house on Poonamalee High Road as it was lying vacant.

As the number of patients seeking dialysis began to shoot up, the Foundation sought a space at Rotary Ambattur Hospital where it got started on the initiative with five machines. Today, the upgraded hospital has 26 machines with 127 patients seeking dialysis under its care.

In the last two decades, this initiative to provide dialysis for patients twice or thrice a week has grown to serve people from various parts of Chennai and beyond. Dialysis is offered either free or at a subsidised rate of ₹ 375 to patients, says a note on its website.

Of the 16 centres run in Tamil Nadu by Tanker Foundation, 11 are in Chennai. “A majority of the patients are enrolled under the Chief Minister Scheme and if expenses beyond that need to be covered we find donors,” says Dr. Georgi Abraham, founder-president of the Tanker Foundation.

The patients have the choice of

opting for a centre that is closest to their home. “A patient whose kidney function is between 6 and 8 percent is eligible for dialysis, but we are particular that certain criteria are met including the financial background of the person and dialysis in an OP setting for free treatment,” says Dr. Georgi.

With rising number of kidney-related ailments, the Foundation sees a huge demand for this from of service. People who require early detection are those with high BP, history of diabetes, complaints of heart disease and a previous history of kidney disease.

For details about its various centres, visit <https://tankerfoundation.org>

GCC-run centres

Greater Chennai Corporation runs dialysis centres in a majority of its zones. As per data put up on X, Zone IX has the maximum number of dialysis machines, 22. The unit functions from Vallorkottam Diagnostic Centre in Nungambakkam. Others are in Thiruvottiyur UCHC, Lakshmiapuram in Retteri UPHC, Elango Nagar UPHC, Padi Ambattur UCHC, Chinnai Porur in Valsarvakam UCHC; Perungudi, Injambakkam and Semmacherry UCHC;

These centres are operated with the support of NGOs and organisations. Dialysis treatment is offered free-of-cost at these centres.

Care at ₹ 600

Since Chennai Lions Dialysis Foundation started in Thiruvanniyur in 2011, one thing that has stayed constant is its affordable pricing. In all these 15 years, the Foundation charges ₹ 600 per sitting from those seeking dialysis.

Started as a pet project of Lion R. Ravichandran, Past District Governor, the Foundation offers dialysis treatment for close to 250 people a month at its six-bed dialysis centre.

The cost of a single haemodialysis session ranges from ₹1800 to ₹ 3,500 in city hospitals. “Since patients need to undergo dialysis sessions two to three times a week, the monthly cost of treatment can run into several thousand rupees. We started this service to alleviate some of the hardships faced by dialysis patients and their families,” says Ravichandran.

The remaining costs are covered by the Foundation. “Although we do face shortage of funds we have somehow been able to sustain this service with the support of donors,” he says.

Nephrologist R. Vijay Kumar is the consultant guiding the Foundation.

Chennai Lions Dialysis Foundation is at No 28A, South Mada Street, Thiruvanniyur, near Marundeeswarar Temple.

For details, call Ravichandran at 98410 51480/ Kalyani Ngarajan at 9841115984.

‘Cooking up’ a challenge for women chefs

Over 70 participants took part in this competition designed to test their culinary knowledge and kitchen skills

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

This dish came to India from Indonesia, according to famous food historian KT Achaya. Cooks employed by Indonesian Hindu kings are believed to have made it between the 9th and 12th centuries. Name the dish.

* Designed by chemist Fred Baur using advanced computing to solve issues with broken and greasy-bagged snacks, this product's signature saddle-like shape is a mathematically optimised hyperbolic paraboloid. It comes packed in canisters to withstand transport pressure. Which engineered snack brand is this?

These two are among the questions that were posted to participants at QuizDiva, a culinary competition for women chefs, culinary professionals, and hospital-



The winners along with dignitaries at the event.

ity students from South India, held at Institute of Hotel Management in Taramani recently.

Over 70 participants found their knowledge and culinary skills tested through different rounds. There were three top prizes worth ₹ 1 lakh, ₹75,000 and ₹ 50,000 to be taken away.

Designed to celebrate talent, creativity, and professional excellence, the event organised by X Quiz IT with South India Chefs Association (SICA) as collaborators

tested the participants on practical culinary challenges, knowledge of food and kitchen skills.

The quiz segments were conducted by X Quiz IT's founder and creative head Arvind Rajeev, while the overall event was handled by Arun Jayakaran Ventures (AJV). "We have done quiz competitions for chefs in the past but this is the first time we were doing something exclusively for lady chefs who were in the fray to showcase their expertise in theo-

ry and practicals. We wanted them to look beyond the books," says quizzier Arvind Rajeev.

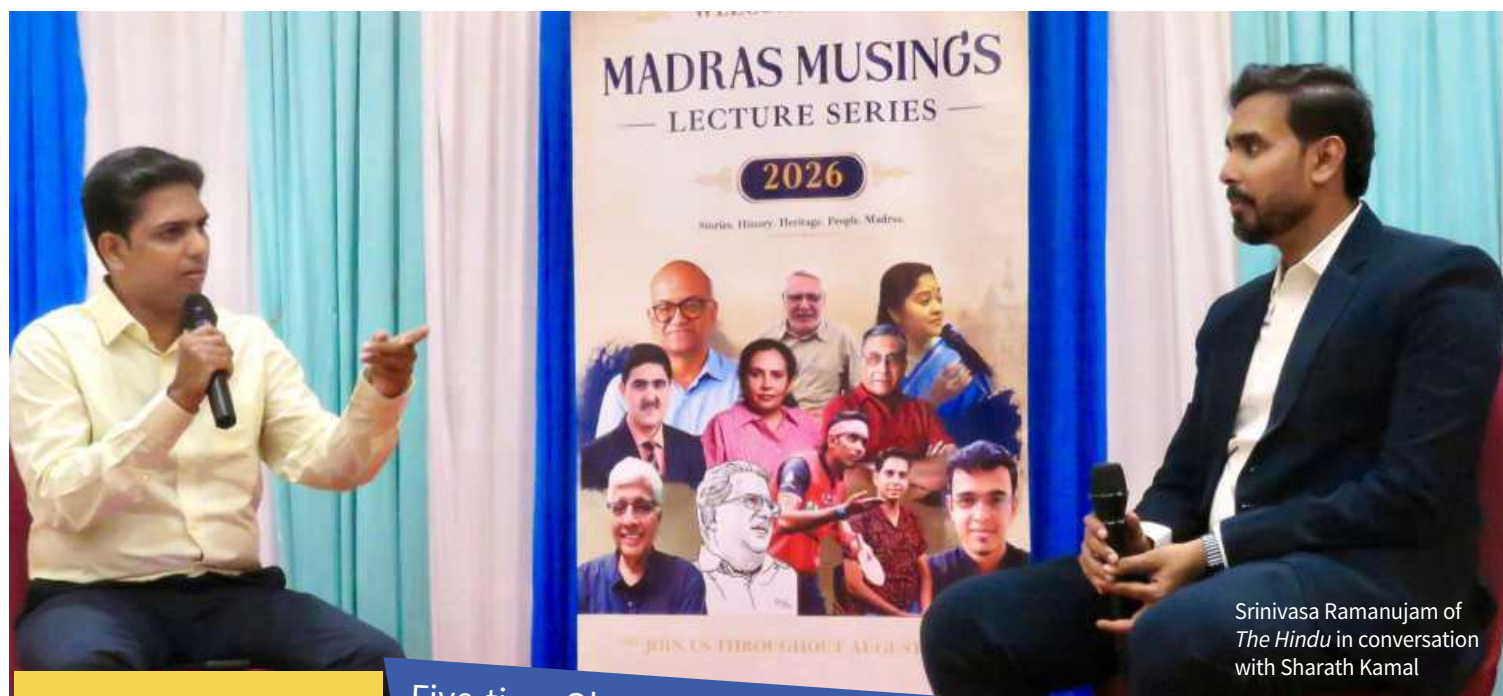
With women in the hospitality industry playing an important role, QuizDiva served as a platform for recognising and encouraging them.

Niranjana Murugesan Durai, a resident of Chennai, won the first prize. After a stint in the hotel industry, she is currently running her own home-based cloud kitchen and plans to use the cash

prize in her business.

Rubah Fathima and Nandhita Sriram were declared second and third prize winners respectively. A new experience for these chefs, the winners pointed out that having a quiz format in the challenge made them take "strategic guesses" and also admire the many female chefs in the industry.

Actor Thalaivasal Vijay was the special guest and he gave away the prizes.



Srinivasa Ramanujam of *The Hindu* in conversation with Sharath Kamal

From tracks to table

Five-time Olympian and table tennis legend Sharath Kamal shares his Madras memories

When table tennis champion Sharath Kamal watched *MS Dhoni: The Untold Story* (2016), he was almost in tears. Much like Dhoni, the now-popular paddler was once a railway TTE at the

Mambalam station in Madras. "There is a scene in the film that has Sushant Singh Rajput (who played Dhoni) sitting in a bench, watching trains go by and wondering if he would remain a ticket collector all his life. I have sat in sta-

tions in Madras exactly like that, before I saw success in table tennis," recalled Sharath.

One of India's most celebrated table tennis players, Sharath went down memory lane at 'The Sporting Side', part of the talks hosted by Madras Musings celebrating Madras Day.

In conversation with Srinivasa Ramanujam, Deputy Editor of *The*

Hindu (Metroplus), the five-time Olympian spoke about the times when he would cycle from Choolaimedu to Mylapore to attend training sessions. "I owe a lot of my success to the city's thriving table tennis culture. I had so many champions to look up to. The club culture here - where we focus on overall growth rather than just individual sporting growth - helped me hone my skills," he recalled.

Sharath, who studied at Padma Seshadri Bala Bhavan and Loyola College, went on to represent India at the highest level, becoming a force to reckon with in the world table tennis circuit. "I have always been a proud Chennaiite. During the time when I lived and trained in Europe, primarily Germany, I would miss the city and my mother's cooking a lot."

Now retired from table tennis, the champion is actively looking at giving back to the sport that gave him name and fame. Part of that will be his involvement in a High Performance centre at Melkottaiyur, a training facility dedicated to grooming future champions. "My unfulfilled dream was to win an Olympic medal for India in table tennis. We hope to achieve that through the younger generation of table tennis talents."

RWAs celebrate I-Day with fervour



The 80th Independence Day was celebrated in a grand manner by various residents welfare associations in and around Tambaram.

Chitlapakkam Muthulakshmi Nagar Welfare Association honoured senior citizens S. Krishnan and Padmavathy Rajam during the I-Day celebration. V. Yoganand, secretary, hoisted the flag. The association president, L. Sundararaman, and the vice presidents, S. Sekar and T. Sivaiah, participated.

Social activist V. Rama Rao, president of the Federation of Senior Citizens' Associations of Tamil Nadu, hoisted the flag at Gericare Hospital in Adambakkam.

Speaking on the occasion, the activist said that as the elderly population is increasing, the need for a geriatric hospital has become greater, and the government should open one in every district. He said the State government should constitute an elders commission, as Kerala has done, with a separate



Celebrations at Chitlapakkam Muthulakshmi Nagar Welfare, Gericare Hospital in Adambakkam; and at Sri Sarvamangala Nagar Residents Association.

budget and an exclusive department for elders.

Dr. B. Balamurugan, senior consultant, nephrology; Dr. Nalini, diabetologist; G. Sethumadhavan; and V. Latha from the federation participated. At Sri Sarvamangala Nagar Residents Association in Chitlapakkam, Sivaswamy, retired Additional Commissioner, Municipal Administration, Government of Tamil Nadu, hoisted the flag.

P. Viswanathan, convenor of the Chitlapakkam Residents Association's



Coordination Committee, and Darwin Annadurai, ecologist at Eco Society India, participated.

Sivaswamy paid homage to freedom fighters and martyrs who lost their lives during the struggle for Independence.

Darwin Annadurai requested the residents to take action to stop sewage discharge into the stormwater drain networks. Waste water from the networks flows into the waterbodies, contaminating the lake and groundwater. To prevent the lakes from becoming contaminated, an underground drainage network is essential.

The Chitlapakkam Anna Nagar Residents' Welfare Association also celebrated Independence Day in a grand manner.

Sadya at Sangeetha Veg

On August 26, Sangeetha Veg Restaurant is serving the traditional Onam sadya. The sadya will feature crisp banana chips, 'sarkara upperi', 'pachadi', 'thoran', 'kootu curry', 'olan', 'kalan' and 'inji puli', along with pickles, 'pappadam', 'pazham', 'parippu' and 'nei', more 'kachiyathu' and other accompaniments. The feast culminates in the irresistible 'pradhaman'.

The Onam sadya at Sangeetha Veg is served at its three outlets - Adyar (9003003087), Virugambakam (7823958667), and Anna Nagar (8680001379) from 11 a.m. to 3 p.m. Dine-in bookings can be made at No. 9003003090.

Payasam mela

Rain Drops, the hospitality venture from Kerala Tourism Development Hotels and Resorts at Greaves Road, is celebrating Onam with a payasam mela and traditional Onam sadya till August 26.

The payasam mela features a delightful variety of traditional Kerala payasams.

A traditional Onam sadya will be served on August 23rd and August 26th with 29 items. A special buffet Onam sadya will also be available, featuring an array of authentic Kerala delicacies.

Cost of payasam is ₹450 per litre and ₹280 for half litre; Onam sadya is ₹899 per person and buffet sadya is ₹599 per person. For bookings and enquiries, WhatsApp: 9498410098, 9188127752 | Phone: 044-28292150



Coffee House opens third outlet in Chennai

Cafe Coffee House has opened its third outlet, located on Dr Thirumoorthy Nagar Main Road, near GG Hospital, Nungambakam. The evening launch was marked by music and special offers, bringing together family, friends, and influencers.

The menu at the outlet includes burgers, pizzas, sandwiches, wraps, pasta, fried chicken, seafood, grilled dishes, and snacks, as well as coffee and other beverages.

Kishore, the outlet founder, says the idea of opening a cafe outlet stemmed from an experience when he was studying in college.

"During my college days, menus at cafes were expensive and would cost around ₹350. My pocket money at the time was around ₹100-₹150. The outlet will offer a café-style experience at more approachable prices."

Changes in pattern of suburban train services

The Chennai Division of the Southern Railway has announced changes in the pattern of electric train services from August 25 to September 6. The change is attributed to work to facilitate Foot Over Bridge (FOB) girders from Platform 9 to 11 up to the New Parcel Office building at Chennai Egmore, a line and power block on the Chennai Beach - Villupuram section at Chennai Egmore Yard, from 23:15 hrs to 04:15 hrs.

Fully cancelled trains

Train numbers : 40083, and 40087, Chennai Beach - Tambaram at 22.20 and 23.20 hours.

Partially cancelled trains

Train No. 40806, Tirumalpur - Chennai Beach at 20 hrs, between Tambaram and Chennai Beach, and Train No. 40206, Guduvancheri - Chennai Beach at 22:15 hrs, between Tambaram and Chennai Beach.

Rescheduling of trains

Train No. 40209, Chennai Beach - Guduvancheri, scheduled to leave at 21:45 hrs, will leave at 21:50 hrs.

Train No. 40569, Chennai Beach - Chengalpattu, scheduled to leave at 22:20 hrs, will leave at 22:15 hrs. Changes in train services from August 26 to September 07

Train No. 40501, Chennai Beach - Chengalpattu EMU at 03:50 hrs, will be partially cancelled between Chennai Beach and Tambaram. For full details, log on to <https://x.com/DrmChennai>

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SUNIL JAYARAM

A community unites for ‘Break The Silence’

It was an evening where the local community did not just gather—it came together to reflect, feel, and wake up.

Set against the scenic backdrop of the lake amphitheater under a cloudy evening sky, PENN and Chitlapakkam Rising organised “Break The Silence”, an event addressing women’s safety, rights, and deep-rooted societal inequality, on August 15 at the Chitlapakkam Lake Amphitheater.

Tackling a subject as sensitive as women’s safety naturally raises questions about how younger generations will interpret it. However, the school and college students who took the stage delivered performances that resonated deeply with the audience, moving spectators to laughter and reflection. Through a carefully curated mix of music, dance, and theatrical content, the youth addressed difficult truths about societal inequality.

The event drew active participation from several prominent institutions, including PENN, alongside local schools—Budding Minds, National, NSN, Rosily, Olive, and St. Marks—and colleges including MCC and SIVET. Contributions from the Chitlapakkam Rising group, Crescent Crescendo, and Ananya further enriched the programme.

A “Yamalagathil BTS”, skit played by the Chitlapakkam Rising group, showcased how crimes



Snapshots of the event; it was graced by actor Revathy. against women are increasing and getting out of control. The skit highlighted some solution to empower women and sensitise our men. School and College performances



portrayed the need for equality and equity. Singappen Task Force officers

from Chitlapakkam Police joined and presented the Force’s new initiatives on women’s safety.

A key highlight of the evening was the presence of noted actor and activist Revathy, who commended the students’ performances and acknowledged the tireless efforts of the local resident volunteers.

“Break the Silence’ at Chitlapakkam was a deeply moving evening, where children and teenagers came together creatively to share two powerful messages: “Raise boys better” and “Build a safer society for women and children.”

Their voices were a powerful reminder that meaningful change begins with awareness, empathy and the courage to speak up,” Revathy said. The evening culminated in a powerful collective pledge: “Vida Maattom! Vida Maattom!” (We will not give up!), signalling a unified local commitment to stand against injustice wherever it occurs.

“PENN’s vision of addressing the Gender Equality & Women, Child Safety thru behavioral change is very well exhibited in the performances of male, female participants thru various Art forms, in

‘Break The Silence’ event organised by Chitlapakkam Rising Community,” said V S Sridhar, Founder and Managing trustee of PENN Trust.

The initiative is part of a broader, ongoing effort to improve the quality of life, safety, and dignity for women and girls in the neighbourhood.

Sunil Jayaram is co-founder Chitlapakkam Rising

Super Chennai brings a ‘fresh vibe’ to Medavakkam

Super Chennai launches “Community Vibes”, conceived as a neighbourhood-led platform that brings together fun, fitness, culture, creativity and learning. The first edition of the initiative focussed on Medavakkam with the “centre stage” parked at a gated community in the locality, Navin’s Starwood

For residents of Medavakkam, a recent Sunday morning began a little differently.

From fitness and games to music, traditional performances and creative workshops, the first edition of Super Chennai Community Vibes brought residents and families together for a morning of shared experiences at Navin’s Starwood on that Sunday.

An initiative by Super Chennai, *Community Vibes* is conceived as a neighbourhood-led platform that brings together fun, fitness, culture, creativity and learning.

The first edition, held between 6 a.m. and 9 a.m. on August 9 saw enthusiastic participation from residents and families from Navin’s Starwood as well as the wider Medavakkam neighbourhood., says a press release from Super Chennai.

The idea behind the initiative is to take community experiences beyond large city-wide events and

into the neighbourhoods where people live.

The morning offered something for different age groups. Families and children had an opportunity to rediscover traditional and native games, many of which are becoming increasingly unfamiliar in today’s urban environment, the release adds.

Children were also at the centre of several hands-on activities. Crochet, live abacus and art

At Community Vibes event in Medavakkam.

workshops gave them opportunities to learn, create and interact in an informal setting, while allowing parents and children to participate together.

The main stage added to the festive mood with a mix of contemporary music and traditional performances. Popular music band Maayavisi performed for the audience, while a Bharatanatyam team from the local community showcased its talent.

Traditional Thappattam and Mayilattam performances brought the sights and sounds of Tamil folk culture to the morning, giving both children and adults an opportunity to experience these art forms up close.

A dedicated music zone further added to the atmosphere, creating a relaxed space for residents to gather, listen and spend time with one another.

The first edition at Navin’s Starwood marked the beginning of what Super Chennai hopes will become a series of such community experiences across Chennai, says the release.